8.1 EU and Orbán

The European Union, a governance structure dominated by political and economic elites, exerts significant influence over its member states, often imposing deep constraints in areas such as trade, environmental policy, agriculture, migration, human rights, and data privacy. While this level of integration fosters unity and cooperation, it also creates vulnerabilities: As a primarily consensus-driven organization, the EU can be disrupted by a single defiant member state. Hungary, under the leadership of its populist prime minister Viktor Orbán, exemplifies this challenge. Since his second term began in 2010, Orbán has consistently voiced euroskepticism and has actively worked to obstruct key elements of the EU's agenda.[1]

Orbán epitomizes the archetype of populist leadership outlined in this book, combining a staunch hostility to elites with an unrelenting defense of sovereignty. He accuses "liberal elites" of distorting the true purpose of European integration and condemns the EU's "detached and empty elite discourse" (Spandler and Söderbaum 2023). His rhetoric often invokes a vision of a "true Europe," one rooted in white Christian identity, and he positions himself as the defender of "average" Europeans against the "elitist" forces in Brussels. By framing his actions as reclaiming sovereignty from the EU, Orbán amplifies his populist appeal.[2]

The EU, for its part, has been sharply critical of Orbán's domestic policies. Since 2011, his government has enacted sweeping constitutional and legislative changes targeting the media, judiciary, central bank, and electoral system, as well as NGOs. These reforms have insulated Orbán from political competition and weakened institutional checks and balances. The EU has also condemned Hungary's treatment of migrants, the LGBTQ+ community, and academics, viewing these actions as emblematic of a broader erosion of democratic norms. Orbán's actions, characterized by the dismantling of civil society and the reshaping of government institutions to his favor, have led the EU to describe Hungary's elections as "free but not fair" (Spandler and Söderbaum 2023).

In defiance of EU norms, Orbán insists that Hungary alone should dictate its domestic policies, particularly on contentious issues like migration, democratic governance, and the rule of law.[3] He has repeatedly obstructed EU initiatives that challenge his nationalist agenda, portraying